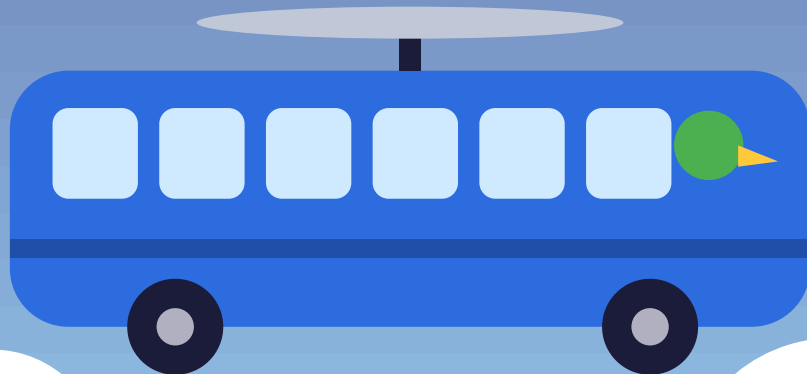


A STORY ABOUT FRIENDSHIP, COURAGE AND KINDNESS

Daniel and the Skyhaven Squad



Written for Daniel and his squad

Riley · Mason · James · Raffi · Ethan · Kai

For Daniel

This book is for Daniel, the best leader a squad could have,
and for his friends Riley, Mason, James, Raffi, Ethan and Kai.

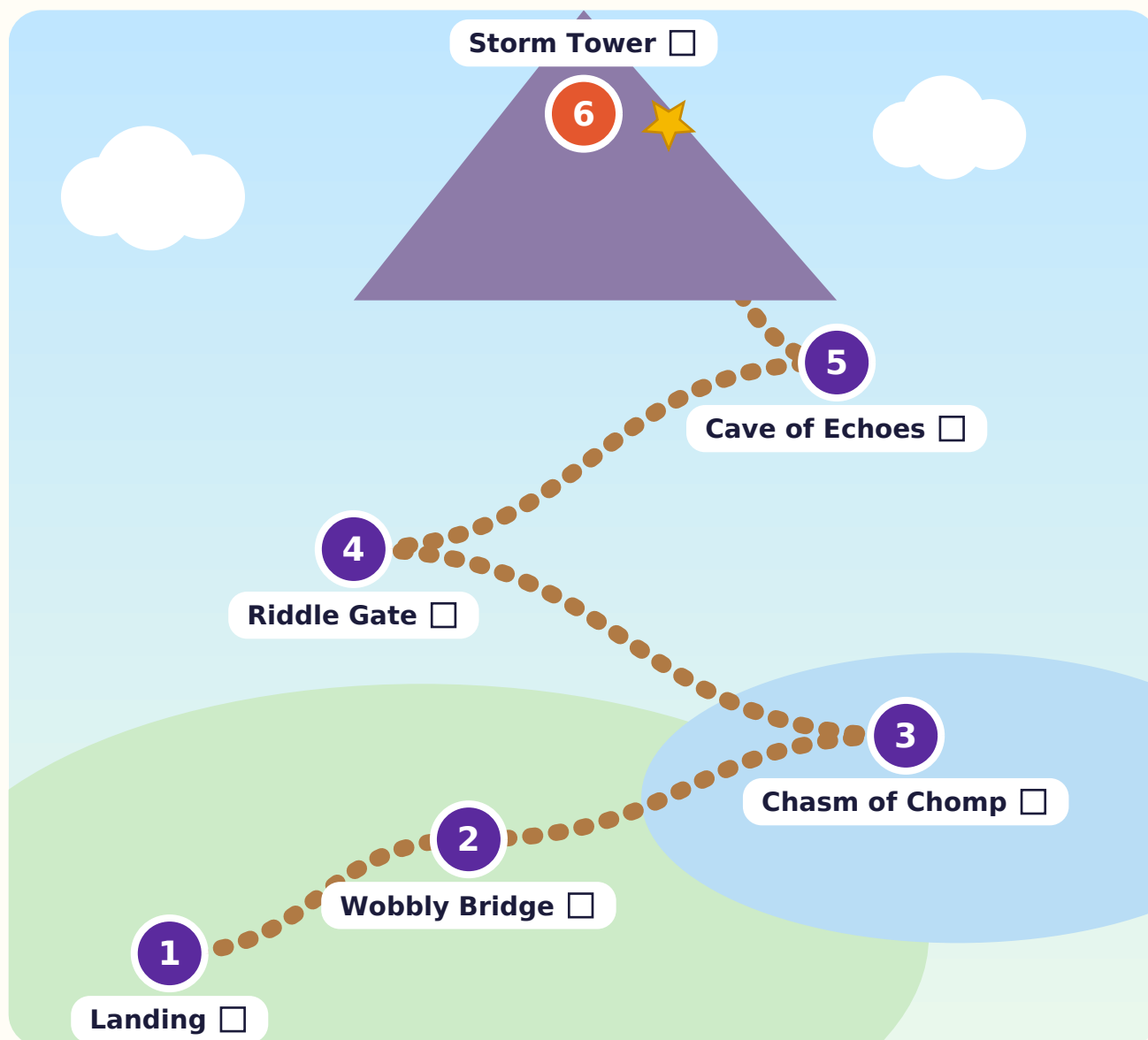
Real friends make every adventure better.

Meet the Squad

Daniel	SUPER-TALENT Leader and Listener	MOTTO "Together we can do anything!"
Riley	SUPER-TALENT Fastest Feet	MOTTO "Never stop running!"
Mason	SUPER-TALENT Master Builder	MOTTO "I can build that."
James	SUPER-TALENT Joke Machine	MOTTO "Laughter is a superpower!"
Raffi	SUPER-TALENT Bravest Heart	MOTTO "Be brave, be kind."
Ethan	SUPER-TALENT Super Brain	MOTTO "Think first, then act."
Kai	SUPER-TALENT Sky Pilot	MOTTO "Stay calm and fly high."

Map of Skyhaven Island

Follow the path to the Storm Tower! Tick each stop when you finish the chapter.



CHAPTER

1

The Golden Ticket



It was the first day of the school holidays, and Daniel was bored. Not a little bit bored. Super-mega-extra bored.

He was lying on his bed, tossing a ball at the ceiling, when something went **CLINK** inside his backpack.

“That's weird,” said Daniel. “I didn't pack anything that clinks.”

He unzipped the bag and pulled out a shiny golden ticket. It glowed like a tiny sun. In curly purple letters it said:

SKYHAVEN NEEDS A HERO SQUAD!
Seven players wanted. The bus leaves at 10
o'clock sharp. Don't be late!

Daniel looked at his clock. It said 9:58.

“TWO **MINUTES?!**” he yelled.

He grabbed his phone and sent the fastest message of his life:

“**EMERGENCY!** Golden ticket! Squad needed NOW! Meet outside!”

Six replies pinged back before he even found his shoes. Riley:

“Running!” Mason: “Bringing my tools.” James: “Is this a prank? I

LOVE it.” Raffi: “Coming! I'm brave!” Ethan: “Interesting. Calculating the fastest route.” Kai: “I'm already looking at the sky.”

Within one minute, six friends skidded around the corner. Riley arrived first (of course). Mason clanked along in a toolbelt. James was laughing already. Raffi was wearing a superhero cape. Ethan was holding a map. Kai had a kite sticking out of a backpack.

Then, at exactly 10 o'clock, the sky went **HONK HONK!** A giant blue bus with spinning silver propellers came whirling down and landed right in Daniel's street.

The doors swung open. "All aboard!" squawked a voice.

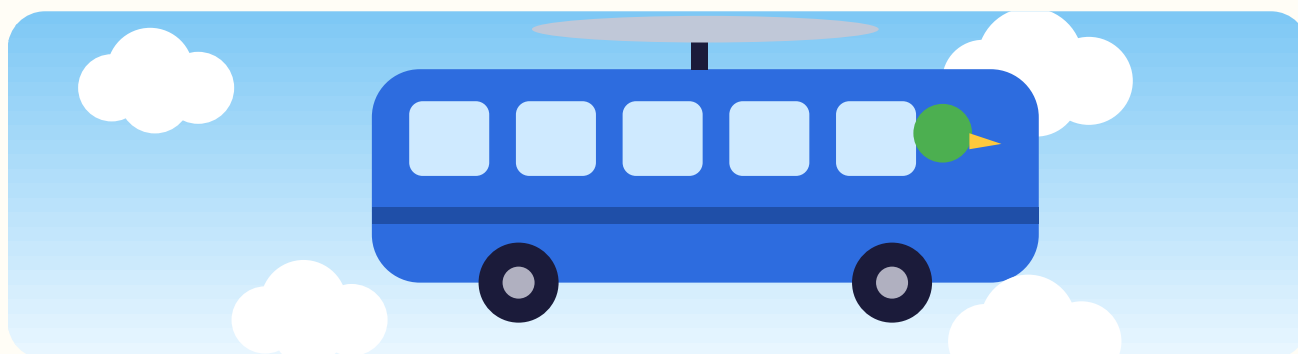
★ **SQUAD CHALLENGE**

If YOU found a golden ticket, where would you want it to take you?

CHAPTER

2

All Aboard the Sky Bus



Inside, the bus smelled like pancakes. The driver was a giant green parrot in a tiny captain's hat.

“Welcome aboard, squad!” squawked Captain Pancake. “Keep your hands inside the bus, your feet off the seats, and your snacks in your tummies!”

The bus lifted off with a **WHOOOOSH**. Houses turned into toys. Cars turned into ants. Daniel pressed his nose against the window and grinned. Then he looked around at his friends.

Riley was the fastest runner in the whole school. Riley's shoelaces were always double-knotted, just in case.

Mason could build anything out of anything. Once, Mason made a skateboard from a cereal box and three spoons. (It only worked a little bit.)

James was the funniest kid anyone knew. James had a joke for every day of the year, and for leap years too.

Raffi was the bravest. Raffi once patted a dog bigger than a sofa and said, “Good boy!”

Ethan was the smartest. Ethan could solve a puzzle faster than you could say “puzzle.”

Kai was the calmest, and the best at flying kites. Kai's kites went higher than the clouds.

And Daniel? Daniel was the squad's leader, because Daniel was a great listener and made everybody feel part of the team.

“So what's the mission?” asked Daniel.

Captain Pancake's face turned serious. “Skyhaven Island floats because of the Great Golden Star. Last night, the Storm stole it. Now the island is sinking, a little more every hour. If we don't get the Star back, Skyhaven will crash!”

“Don't worry,” said Daniel. “We'll get it back. Together.”

Out of the window, a floating island appeared above the clouds, with waterfalls pouring UP into the sky. “Next stop,” squawked Captain Pancake, “Skyhaven!”

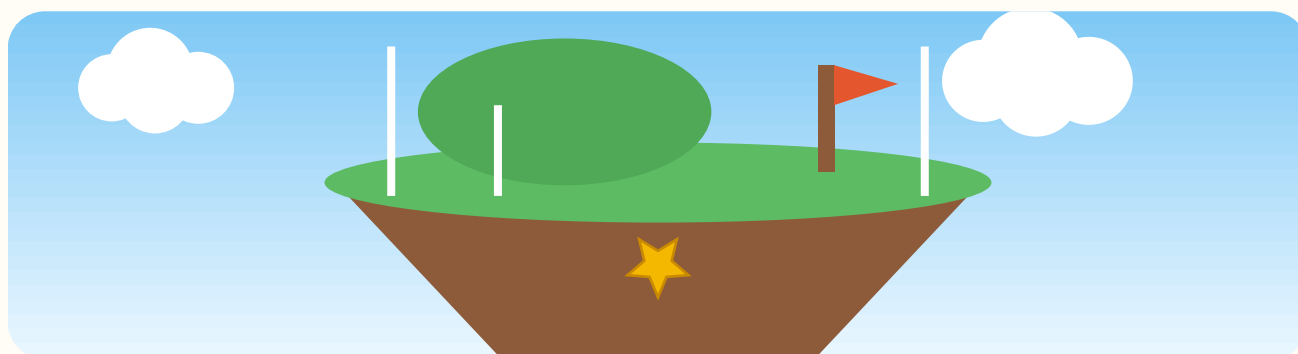
★ **SQUAD CHALLENGE**

Which friend's talent would you most love to have? Why?

CHAPTER

3

Skyhaven in Trouble



The bus landed with a bounce. Everything on Skyhaven was a little bit tilted. A bench slid by. A watering can rolled away. James had just been handed an ice cream when the ground tipped, and the ice cream slid off its cone. “My ice cream is escaping!” wailed James.

A tiny llama in a giant top hat was standing on a box. “I am Mayor Fluff,” said the llama. “Thank goodness you're here!”

The Mayor unrolled a long scroll. “The Storm lives in the Storm Tower, at the top of Crooked Mountain. To get there, you must pass five tests:”

1. The Wobbly Bridge
2. The Chasm of Chomp
3. The Riddle Gate
4. The Cave of Echoes
5. The Storm Tower itself

“Easy peasy,” said James. Everybody looked at James. “...Okay, maybe not easy. But peasy.”

Mayor Fluff gave every member of the squad a golden badge shaped like a star. Daniel pinned his on and felt a warm tingle. “Squad,” said Daniel, “let's go save Skyhaven!”

The squad marched toward Crooked Mountain. Behind them, the island tilted a tiny bit more. Tick-tock, tick-tock.

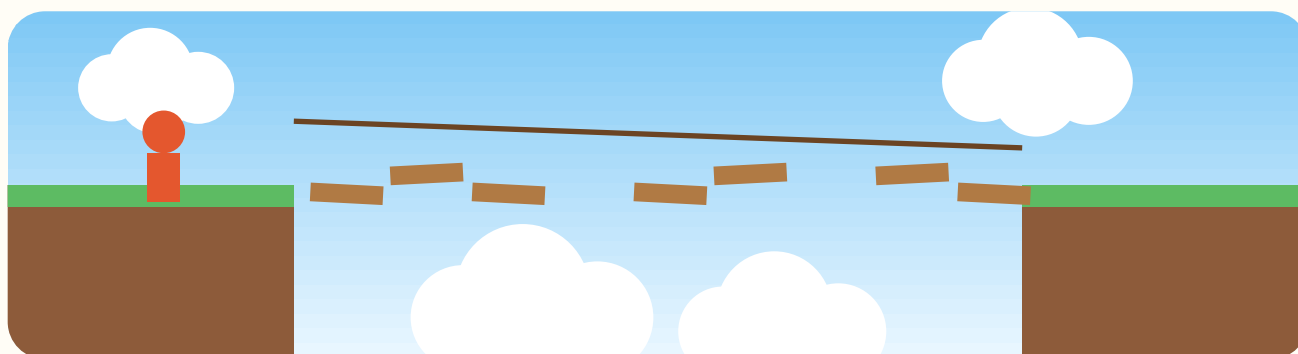
★ **SQUAD CHALLENGE**

Make up a funny name for a place on Skyhaven Island. What would it be?

CHAPTER

4

Riley and the Wobbly Bridge



The first test was the Wobbly Bridge. It was made of old wooden planks, hanging over a river of white, fluffy clouds. And it was wobbling like jelly on a trampoline.

WHOOOSH! A strong gust of wind blew. Two planks flew off and spun away into the sky.

“Nobody panic,” said Daniel. “Riley, what do you see?”

Riley watched the bridge carefully. “The wind comes in waves,” said Riley. “Big gust... pause... big gust... pause. If we run during the pause, we'll make it!”

“Follow my footsteps,” said Riley. “Step where I step!”

Riley counted: “One... two... **THREE!**” and zoomed across like a rocket. Skip-skip-hop! On the other side, Riley waved both arms.

One by one, the squad followed. Mason slid. Ethan counted out loud. Raffi was brave until the bridge went wobble-wobble, then Raffi said, “Eeeek!” but kept going. James was laughing so hard that James nearly fell off, but Kai grabbed a hand just in time.

Daniel was last. **WHOOOSH!** The wind blew, but Daniel waited for the pause, then ran with all the speed his legs had. He leaped onto solid ground, and the bridge spun away behind him.

At the end of the bridge, a little silver key hung from a hook. Riley picked it up. “One key down. Four tests to go!”

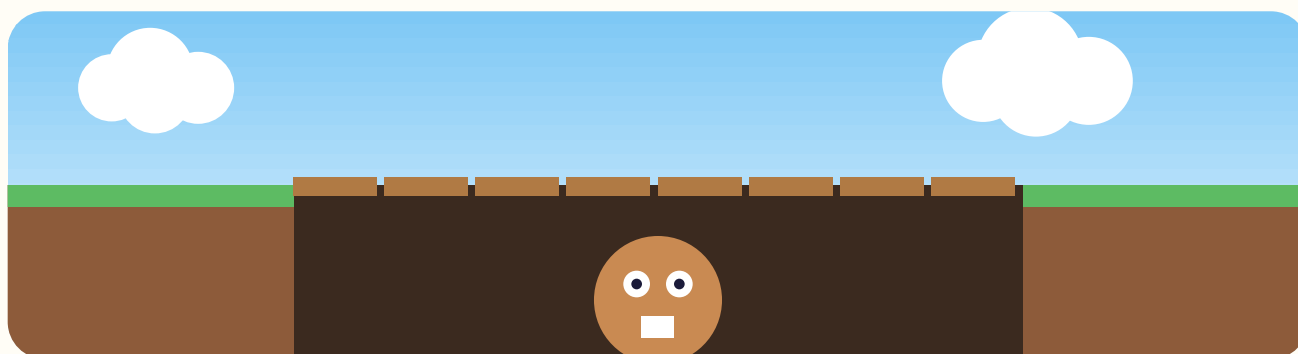
★ **SQUAD CHALLENGE**

Riley spotted a pattern in the wind. Can you find a pattern in your classroom or at home?

CHAPTER

5

Mason's Big Build



The next test was the Chasm of Chomp. It was a gigantic gap in the ground, so wide that the other side looked tiny. Down at the bottom, something went **CHOMP CHOMP CHOMP**.

“Nope,” said James. “I’m not falling into that.”

Big floating rocks and old planks drifted past in the air. Mason’s eyes lit up. “I can build with those,” said Mason.

“How much do we need?” asked Daniel. Ethan whipped out a measuring tape. “The gap is exactly 12 meters,” said Ethan. “We’ll need at least 13 meters of bridge to be safe. And a sturdy ramp at each end.”

“Perfect,” said Mason, cracking both knuckles. “Everybody, I need teamwork.”

Everyone got a job. Riley raced around collecting planks. Kai tied ropes with perfect knots. Raffi held the ladder. James told jokes to keep everybody cheerful (“Why was the math book sad? It had too many problems!”). Ethan checked every measurement twice. Daniel passed tools to Mason and said, “You’ve got this.”

Mason hammered, sawed and wiggled. **BANG! CLANG! CLUNK!** Slowly a bridge grew across the chasm, with railings and everything.

Down in the chasm, the **CHOMP** sound got louder. “Don’t look down,” said Daniel. “Look at the bridge. Look at your friends.” One by one

they crossed. Halfway over, Raffi peeked over the edge. “Squad, the chomper is a hamster!” It was the size of a football, with a wiggly nose. Raffi tossed it half a sandwich. **CHOMP!** The hamster purred.

On the other side, Mason patted the last plank. “Told you I can build anything out of anything.”

★ **SQUAD CHALLENGE**

What would YOU build to cross the chasm? Draw it!

CHAPTER

6 The Riddle Gate



At the end of a long, winding path stood a huge stone gate, with a giant face carved in the middle. The face had sleepy eyes and a very long mustache.

"I am Gus, the Gatekeeper," rumbled the gate. "To pass, you must answer my riddle. You get three guesses."

The gate cleared its throat. "I have keys, but no locks. I have space, but no room. You can enter, but you can't go inside. What am I?"

"A piano?" guessed Raffi. "Nope," said Gus. "A castle?" said Mason. "Nope." "A... pizza?" said James. "WHY would a pizza have keys?" said Gus. "...Extra-cheese keys?" said James. Everyone giggled.

Last guess. Ethan closed both eyes and thought. "Keys... space... enter..." Suddenly Ethan's eyes popped open. "It's something we all use every day!"

"It's a **KEYBOARD!**" said Ethan. "It has keys, a space bar and an Enter key!"

The gate went quiet. Then its stone mouth fell open. "Nobody has solved that one in a hundred years," said Gus.

CLUNK-CLUNK-CLANG! The gate swung open, and a second key, a golden one, dropped into Ethan's hand.

"Great job, Ethan!" said Daniel. "Your brain is amazing." Ethan grinned. "Just a regular brain. A very good one."

★ SQUAD CHALLENGE

Can you make up your own riddle? Ask someone at home and see if they can solve it!

CHAPTER

7

The Cave of Echoes



Next came a dark, gloomy cave. “Hello?” called Raffi. “Hello... hello... hello...” answered the echo. “Cool!” said James. “James is the best! ...best... best...” “Funny,” said Mason. “The echo agrees.”

Deep inside the cave, the squad heard a noise like a thousand tractors snoring: **ZZZZZZRRRRRRR**.

They tiptoed around the corner and froze. In the middle of the tunnel lay the biggest, fluffiest creature they had ever seen. It was as big as a bus, as purple as a plum, and had paws the size of dustbin lids. It was blocking the whole tunnel.

Ethan checked the Mayor's scroll. “It says here that this is a Snorebear. Snorebears are friendly, but terrified of thunder.”

“We need to wake it up... gently,” said Daniel. “Raffi?”

Raffi gulped. Then Raffi stood tall, tiptoed forward and tapped one giant paw. “Excuse me, Snorebear?”

One enormous eye opened. Then the other. The Snorebear sat up and sniffled. “Is the thunder gone?” it asked in a tiny, shaky voice. “The storm has been rumbling for days. I'm too scared to move.”

“We're going to stop the storm,” said Raffi. “I promise.” And Raffi gave the huge creature a gentle pat on the nose.

“But I'm still scared,” sniffled Snuffles, shaking so hard that little stones fell from the ceiling.

James stepped forward. “Hey, Snuffles, want to hear a joke? What do you call a bear with no teeth?”

Snuffles giggled. Then Snuffles chuckled. Then Snuffles laughed so hard that the whole cave shook. “HAR HAR HAR! A gummy bear!” Little glowing stones fell from the ceiling like confetti.

“I haven't laughed in years,” said Snuffles, wiping away a tear. “You may pass. And take this.” Snuffles gave Raffi a glowing blue stone. “It shines when someone nearby is sad. May it help you.”

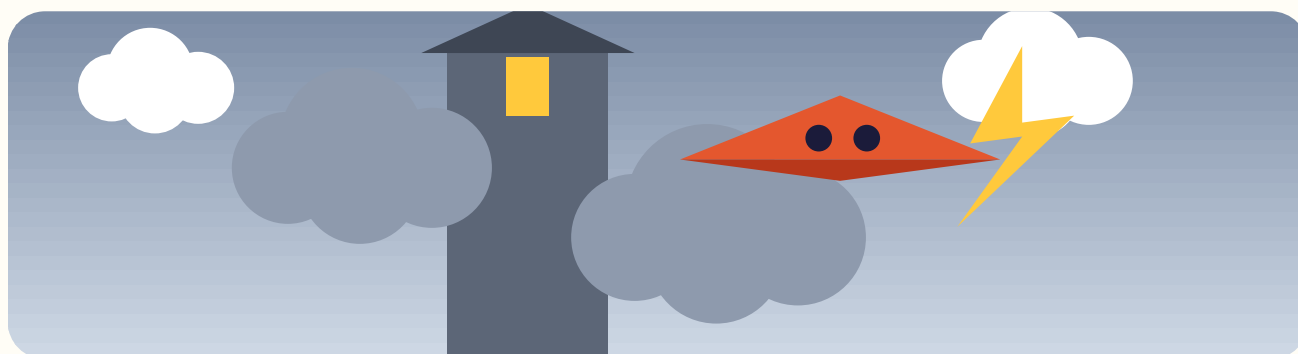
The squad squeezed past, while Snuffles waved a giant paw goodbye. Daniel put the glowing stone in his pocket. It felt warm.

★ SQUAD CHALLENGE

Do you have a joke that makes people laugh? Tell it to someone today!

CHAPTER

8 Kai Takes Flight



At last, the squad reached the bottom of the Storm Tower. It was as tall as a hundred houses, wrapped in swirling gray clouds, with lightning flashing around the roof. The wind blew so hard it could flip a pancake.

“There's no door,” said Ethan. “Only one window, right at the top.” Everyone looked up. Way, way up.

“We can't climb that,” said Mason. “We can only fly.” Everyone looked at Kai. Kai smiled calmly. “I do have a glider.”

It was the kite from Kai's backpack! On Skyhaven, everything grows bigger and better. It stretched and puffed and became a real glider, with bright red wings and a seat for two.

“The wind is too strong for a normal takeoff,” said Kai. “We need a launch.” Daniel took charge. “Okay, team. Here's the plan.”

“Mason, build a ramp! Riley, run beside the glider and push as hard as you can. Ethan, tell us the best angle. Raffi, check the ropes. James, cheer the loudest!” “Loud is my superpower,” said James.

Daniel climbed into the second seat. Mason's ramp was ready. “Thirty degrees,” said Ethan. “Exactly.” Riley pushed. James yelled, “GO GO GO GO GO GO!” The glider zoomed down the ramp and... **WHOOSH!** It flew.

The wind pushed and pulled. Lightning flashed. Daniel held on tight and squeezed his eyes shut. “Daniel, open your eyes,” said Kai calmly. “Look. We're flying.” Daniel looked. Clouds were below them. Skyhaven's green hills spread out like a map. “WOW.”

Kai steered through the wind like a fish through water: left, right, a loop-the-loop and around the tower. Up, up, up, until the window was right in front of them. They landed gently on a little balcony.

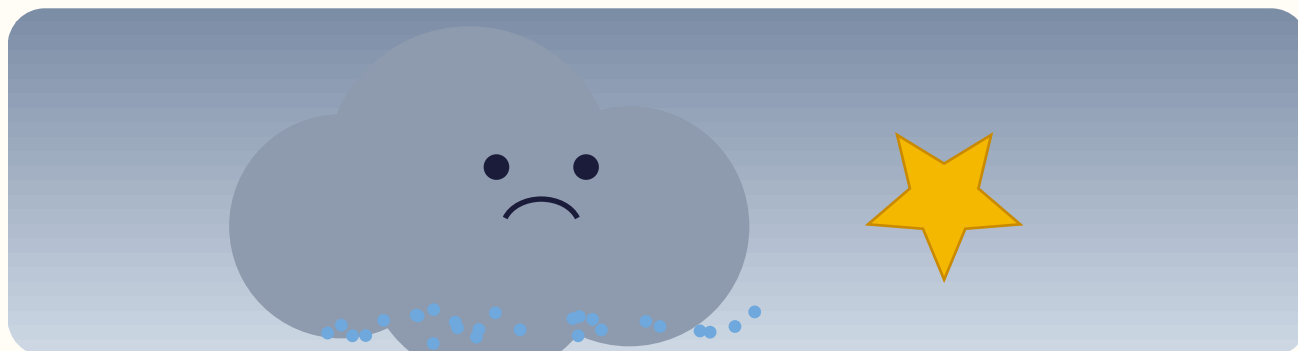
Down on the ground, the squad cheered so loud that the Snorebear heard it in the cave. Daniel took a deep breath and pushed the window open.

★ **SQUAD CHALLENGE**

If you could fly anywhere in a glider, where would you go?

CHAPTER

9 Meet Grumble



Inside the tower was one gigantic room, dark and cold. In the middle, on a huge chair, sat the biggest gray cloud Daniel had ever seen. It had two big sad eyes and a droopy mouth. In its arms (well, puffs) it held the Great Golden Star, glowing softly.

“GO **AWAY!**” boomed the cloud. Thunder rumbled. Rain dripped from its eyes. “Everybody runs away when I come near! GO **AWAY!**”

Daniel's pocket felt warm. He pulled out Snuffles's glowing stone. It was shining brighter than ever, as bright as a lamp. “It's glowing because someone nearby is sad,” whispered Daniel. He looked at the cloud. “It's you.”

Daniel stepped forward. His knees were wobbling, but he remembered what a good leader does: listen. “Hi. I'm Daniel. What's your name?”

“...Grumble,” sniffled the cloud. “My name is Grumble.”

“Why did you take the Star, Grumble?” asked Daniel gently.

Grumble's lip wobbled. “I live all alone in this dark tower. Every time I rumble, everybody runs away. I just wanted something shiny and warm, so that someone, anyone, would come and visit me.” A tear rolled down, plip! and became a tiny raindrop.

Daniel nodded slowly. “I think I understand. You're not scary, Grumble. You're lonely.” “...Am I?” whispered Grumble.

The squad came forward. “Hi, Grumble,” said Riley. “I can run faster than a rocket.” “I can build you a comfy chair,” said Mason. Raffi gave the cloud a big pat. “You’re so fluffy.” “I’ll teach you riddles,” said Ethan. “Want to fly my kite?” asked Kai. “And I’ve got a joke,” said James. “What do clouds wear under their clothes?” “...What?” said Grumble. **“THUNDERWEAR!”**

Grumble’s big sad face wobbled. Then it twitched. Then Grumble burst out laughing, a huge rumble laugh like a hundred drums.

“HAHAHAHA!” Thunderwear!” And the raindrops turned into twinkling sparkles.

“Nobody ever visited me before,” said Grumble. “I’m sorry I took the Star. Here you go.” Grumble handed the Great Golden Star to Daniel. It glowed bright and warm.

“Thank you,” said Daniel. “And you know what? You can visit Skyhaven any time you like.”

★ **SQUAD CHALLENGE**

Has someone at your school ever been lonely? What kind thing could you do?

CHAPTER

10

The Great Skyhaven Party



Daniel raised the Star high. A beam of golden light shot out of the tower and up into the sky. The whole island shuddered. Then, slowly, Skyhaven rose higher and higher, standing straight again.

Down in the village, everybody cheered. Mayor Fluff threw the top hat into the air. Captain Pancake flapped around the bus, yelling “HIP HIP **HOORAY!**”

That night, Skyhaven threw the biggest party in history, and Grumble was the guest of honor. Grumble sat in the middle of the village, rumbling with laughter, and the sparkles rained down on everyone like glitter.

Mayor Fluff gave every member of the squad a golden medal: Riley (Fastest Feet), Mason (Master Builder), James (Giggle Champion), Raffi (Bravest Heart), Ethan (Super Brain) and Kai (Sky Pilot). Daniel got the Leader's Medal: “For listening, and for kindness.”

They danced, they ate pancakes (thanks to Captain Pancake) and they ate cloud candy floss in every flavor. Even Snuffles the Snorebear showed up, laughing at James's jokes.

At sunset, Captain Pancake honked the bus horn. “All aboard! Time to go home!” The squad waved goodbye to Grumble, who promised, “I’ll rain sparkles every Saturday!”

On the way home, they sat in the bus, tired and happy. Daniel looked at his friends. Riley, Mason, James, Raffi, Ethan and Kai were the best squad in the whole wide world.

The bus landed in Daniel's street. Daniel looked at his clock. It was still 10 o'clock. "How is that possible?" he laughed.

In his hand, the golden ticket glowed one last time. New words appeared in curly purple letters:

**THANK YOU, HERO SQUAD!
SEE YOU AT THE NEXT ADVENTURE...**

Daniel smiled. He couldn't wait.

★ **SQUAD CHALLENGE**

What should the squad's NEXT adventure be? Write or draw your idea on the next page!



THE END
(for now!)

Squad Quiz

How well did you read? Answer in full sentences. Answers are at the bottom of the page.

1. What did Daniel find in his backpack?

2. Who drives the Sky Bus?

3. What keeps Skyhaven floating?

4. Who figured out the pattern in the wind?

5. What was making the CHOMP sound in the chasm?

6. What was the answer to Gus's riddle?

7. What is Snuffles the Snorebear afraid of?

8. Who flew the glider?

9. Why did Grumble take the Star?

10. What special thing did Daniel do that helped Grumble?

Answers: 1. A golden ticket. 2. Captain Pancake, a giant green parrot. 3. The Great Golden Star. 4. Riley. 5. A hamster. 6. A keyboard. 7. Thunder. 8. Kai. 9. Grumble was lonely and wanted visitors. 10. Daniel listened and was kind.

Your Next Adventure!

Where should the Skyhaven Squad go next? Draw the place and write what happens.

Draw it here:



Write about it:
